

THE FRIEND THEY MOURNED (FOUR KEYS)

THE SPINE, v1.0

2026-08-30. Pipeline step 1, step 1b with the recipient column, and step 2. Written against premise v8 (closed to premise attack), the five v1.2, and the Four Keys rulings in memory. No prose. Nothing in this document reaches Fable except Part G.

Status: the sweep PASSES. No person's earliest competent action ends the episode before its planned turn. Two locks are thin and are named as such in Part C: Margo's six days between her turn and Brad's vanish, and Ruby's open route to Del from Day 27, which is open, computed, and does not deliver. Eight rulings are queued for Stephen in Part E; the spine holds under the answers it asks for and says what breaks otherwise.

Two objects chosen here (Part D). X, what Violet hid, is a gilded alphabet panel Brad made in a hand he had never shown anyone, signed with a mark that is not his name. Fable's brush, sable on an oar handle, fails three of the seven constraints as X and is the decoy instead. Fable's Violet gave us the decoy without knowing it.

Decided here, from v8's open list: the motive (the money, below) · the cupboard (Violet's storage cage, Bay 4, the back corridor of the fish market) · the meeting room (Ruby's kitchen) · the cliff (Kestrel Head, the drop beyond Kestrel Point Lighthouse at the end of Kestrel Road; canon landmark, cliff not yet built) · the source of Violet's money (her mother's cash, taken from the house the week she died, told only to Margo) · the span (Day 0 to Day 333, with Brad's first preparation at Day -900) · which survivor comes to Ally (Ruby first, Liam by episode four) · neither survivor is anything to Ally already.

THE GRAPH, IN ONE TABLE

The whole truth, once, so every later part can be checked against it. Everything below is known in full only to Brad.

What actually happened	Day
Brad builds an exit under a name that was never his: the birth record of a boy who died in infancy 400 miles away, then the documents that follow from it. No accomplice.	-900 to -500
He hollows the trade: cash where offered, declared turnover falling year on year. The pub that changes its name every spring pays him cash at his request.	-850 onward
He rents a room 400 miles away, cash, quarterly in advance, as a lodger in a widow's house. Weekend absences begin, told as customers up the coast.	-400
He makes the panel on Tuesday nights at Violet's bench after she has gone, and keeps it in the roof space over her paint racks, because his flat and van must stay clean.	-380 to -80
Violet tells Margo she is calling in what she is owed, for the lawyer in the fight with her sister. The largest debt is Brad's: the van and first stock, cash, no paper, from Day -2000. She tells Brad on Day -110.	-120
Brad decides she dies before he goes. From inside: a debt follows a man who moves and not a man who dies; a man who dies needs a grief; hers is the one grief that makes his vanish read true; and she has never cost him anything he valued.	-110

What actually happened	Day
A roof leak. Violet finds the wrapped panel above the racks. She carries it round town for a month asking whose hand. Brad hears from the café on Day -40.	-75
The ladder. Brad undoes the foot bolt of the Regent ladder the night before; she falls from the third rung; hip; Ruby treats it at the surgery. Violet finds the bolt undone, not sheared, and tells nobody.	-45
Violet changes the cage padlock, has four keys cut on Lantern Street, writes five letters, hides panel and letter in the cage, lodges four envelopes with her solicitor: post after my funeral.	-20 to -18
Brad walks to Mariner's Row about the money. She goes up for the debt book. The stairs. He waits twenty minutes, takes the book, leaves by the back lane.	0
Accident. The four keys. Brad reads the cage on Day 16, writes at her bench on Day 17, swaps on Day 18. The panel leaves with him on Day 53 in a bag hidden at the ridge wall.	1 to 53
He contacts Margo from a cash prepaid on the channel she uses for Tessa, walks 19 miles in from the inland halt on Day 214, and pushes her from the point. Her phone and his prepaid go into the sea.	180 to 215
Ally arrives after the front page. Her listeners find the pieces. The panel is described on air on Day 325 and is gone from his wall by Day 326. His landlady writes that night. The reference sample taken to identify his body identifies him alive.	266 to 333

A. THE CLOCK

Day 0 is the Monday Violet dies. Negative days precede it. Times are given where they matter. Weeks in Part C: Week 1 = Days 0 to 6.

A1. Before

Day	Event	Who knows
-2000	Violet lends Brad the van and first stock from the tin. No paper. She asks Margo whether a loan needs paper; Margo says yes; Violet does not.	Violet, Brad, Margo
-1500	Violet's mother dies; Liam drives them in the last night. Violet clears the house first and takes the cash her mother kept. The sister does not know.	Violet; Liam knows the night, not the cash
-1450	Violet asks Margo whether cash from her mother is taxable. Margo notes it in her own file. This is the only record of where the money came from.	Violet, Margo
-1200	The sister moves to sell the house. The dispute begins. Violet instructs a solicitor on Civic Row.	Violet, sister, solicitor, later all four
-900	Brad obtains the birth record of a boy born his year who died in infancy 400 miles away (public register). Over the next year, the documents that follow from it.	Brad
-850 →	Cash where offered. The pub landlord pays cash from Day -700 at Brad's request. Declared turnover falls.	Brad; the pub landlord; Margo sees the pub's side of it
-600	Violet notices Margo has a Sunday, and a green app she checks at the slip. She says so to Brad, the only one she talks to about the other three.	Violet, Brad
-400	Brad rents the room, cash, quarterly, as a lodger. Weekend absences begin.	Brad; the landlady knows a lodger under the other name
-380 → -80	The panel, Tuesday nights at Violet's bench after she leaves, kept in the roof space over the racks.	Brad
-250	Brad runs a marathon in another city under three hours and tells the four it was a wedding.	Brad; Ruby sees the result page on Day -200 and says nothing

Day	Event	Who knows
-200	In the crane cab Brad asks Liam what the yard would give for the van, cash, spring maybe.	Brad, Liam
-120	Violet tells Margo she is calling in what she is owed. The list, in Violet's hand, names Brad and the sum.	Violet, Margo
-110	Violet tells Brad. Brad decides.	Violet, Brad
-75	The leak. Violet finds the panel.	Violet
-70 → -40	Violet shows the panel to the cinema owner, the café, two other signwriters on the coast: whose hand is this.	Those four people; Brad from the café on Day -40
-46 night	Brad, with his unit key, undoes the foot bolt on the Regent ladder.	Brad
-45	Violet falls from the third rung onto the cobbles. Hip. Ruby treats her at Wharf Street and records a fall from a ladder. Violet finds the bolt undone.	Violet, Ruby (the fall only)
-20	New padlock on Cage 4. Four keys cut at the locksmith on Lantern Street; his book records four copies, that date.	Violet, locksmith
-19	Violet writes four key letters and one cage letter, hides panel and letter in the cage.	Violet
-18	She lodges four sealed envelopes with the solicitor: post these after my funeral. He asks; she makes a joke about her sister.	Violet, solicitor
-18 → -1	Nothing visible. Tuesday visits, the slip, the receipts bag.	

A2. The death and the keys

Day	Time	Event
0 Mon	21:30	Brad walks to Mariner's Row, phone left at his flat. She lets him in. The money.
0	21:55	She goes up for the debt book. He follows. The landing, the light off. One push.
0	22:20	She stops breathing at the foot of the stairs. He has not touched her again. He takes the book.
0	22:30	Out by the back door, latched behind him. The neighbour at N ^o 14 sees a man's back in the lane and thinks nothing.
1 Tue	06:00	Ruby's text, then Ruby's car at the slip. No Violet. Ruby assumes the Regent ladder, early.
1	12:30	Liam at the unit. Shut.
1	13:10	Liam at the house with the spare key. Finds her. 13:14 he rings it in.
1	14:00	Uniform, then the Harbor Ward sergeant (Del) at a sudden death: unwitnessed, head injury, foot of the stairs, front locked, back latched, no disturbance, two glasses of wine on the side. Coroner's officer informed. Door-knock: N ^o 14 saw her Monday morning.
2		Liam into the unit, heater off, finds the tin. Rings the sister. Ruby reads Violet's record at the surgery: the ladder fall.
3		Post-mortem (Cortez): skull fracture and brain injury consistent with a fall down a domestic stair; healed bruising to the hip; blood alcohol modest. GP record shows a fall six weeks earlier.
5		The sister arrives. Liam hands her the tin in front of Ruby and Margo. All four now know of the tin.
6		Coroner opens and adjourns. Body released.
11 Fri		Funeral. The wake photograph: the four together.
12 Sat		The solicitor posts four envelopes.
14 Mon		Four keys and four letters arrive. The letter says: I think one of you is planning to kill me, I do not know which, I may be wrong, do not go to the police and here is why, what I found is behind this door, only the four of you can read it. Cage 4 is named. They ring each other that night and agree Saturday.

Day	Time	Event
16 Wed	05:40	Brad at Cage 4, market hours, van in the loading bay. Reads the cage letter, takes it and the panel. The fishmonger at Bay 3 says early for you.
17 Thu	night	Brad at Violet's bench with his unit key. Her layout paper, her pen. He writes it there, where practice sheets in her style are invisible among her own. Takes the brush from the bucket. Burns the drafts in his sink. Puts the pen back.
18 Fri	05:30	Brad places the letter and the brush in Cage 4.
19 Sat	10:00	The four open Cage 4. A letter in her hand that says I know, and the brush. Read at Ruby's kitchen table. Margo asks why the brush is here and is answered: she is telling us something. Brad says she might have been wrong about all of it. Weekly meetings agreed.

A3. The room

Day	Event
26	Meeting 2. The letter's line about the yard is read against Liam.
27	Liam confirms he owns a third of the yard. A fact in the letter is true. Ruby is shaken. Margo, who did not know, says nothing about the money she does know.
33	Meeting 3. The tin. The letter says the money is Liam's, paid quarterly since the yard. Liam: I never gave her a penny. Brad: she might have been wrong about the money, and if she was wrong about that she was wrong about the rest; we cannot do this to Liam on a maybe. He loses.
40	Meeting 4. The ladder. The letter says she had told Liam which ladder. Liam: she told everyone which ladder. Margo begins the sums.
44	Margo opens her own file. Day –1450, in her hand: cash, mother, no tax. The letter has the money wrong. Violet did not lie to them. So the letter is not Violet's. So somebody wrote it, before Saturday, and left a real thing of hers beside it.
45 to 47	The sums at three in the morning come out the same. The one person who kept the room on Liam by defending him.
46	Brad had already placed the bag at the ridge wall: clothes, cash, the panel wrapped, on a customer run. Ready since Day 30. Margo is the trigger, not the plan.
47	Meeting 5. Margo stops arguing with Brad and stops looking at the other two. Brad notices.
53 Sun 22:40	Van to the Kestrel Head car park. 23:12 one message to the group thread: I can't do this any more. I'm sorry. Phone on the seat. The watch, smashed with a stone, thrown to the rocks. 23:30 the coast path inland, then the ridge path.
54 Mon 05:47	First train from the inland halt, cash single. 15:00 at the lodgings, a job that ran late.
54 06:30	A dog walker finds the van. Police. Del. Coastguard search Days 54 to 56. Flat searched Day 54 evening: passport, cards, tools, laptop, all present.
55	Watch found at the base. Reference sample: toothbrush, razor, prints lifted from the flat. Missing person, high risk, presumed in the water. Interviews Days 55 to 56: Ruby, Liam, Margo, each says grief. None mentions the letters.
57 →	The three keep meeting. Ruby drives it.
70	Margo to Tessa on the app: the thing in the cupboard is wrong. It can't mean that. Tessa screenshots it because Margo does not say things like that.
82	The sister, clearing the unit, cuts the padlock on Cage 4. Empty.
84	Brad's rent stops.
89	It lands. Ruby says it to Liam's face. Liam leaves and does not come back.
110	The landlord clears the flat. Boxes to Ruby.
90 → 213	Liam and Ruby do not speak. Margo withdraws from Ruby. Margo drives to Tessa every second Sunday.

A4. The stranger, the return, the second death

Day	Event
180	A new contact on the green app, from a number that leads nowhere: you're the one who stopped believing the letter. Brad has her number from the group and knew the app from Violet.
180 → 212	He knows the wording of the message, the watch, the time on the car park clock. He says Brad was not alone that night. Everything points her away from Brad and towards the woman who ran every meeting. Everything deletes. Margo does not turn: she keeps arriving at the man who defended Liam.
212	Sunday. The point. Eleven. I'll show you where he went down and you'll see it isn't what they said.
213 Sat	Brad tells the landlady a job away Sunday to Monday. Train south, cash, two changes.
214 Sun 17:10	The last Sunday train reaches the inland halt. He walks the ridge path, 19 miles.
214 20:00	Margo leaves Tessa's early: work first thing.
214 22:50	Margo's car in the Kestrel Head car park, ten minutes early. She sits in the car until the hour.
214 23:00	The point. He asks to see what he sent her. She hands him the phone. He pockets it.
214 23:10	She goes over. Her phone and his prepaid off the point into deep water at 23:20.
215 Mon 05:47	The first train. The clerk sells a cash single to a man with wet boots and complains about the change. A woman on the platform notices the boots.
215 06:40	The same dog walker finds the car. Police. Search.
215 12:00	Tessa rings Margo's office. 15:30 Tessa rings the police: a partner nobody in Havenbay knew.
215	Del pulls Brad's file beside it: two of Violet Moore's four, same car park, five months apart.
218	Margo's body in Havenbay harbour. Post-mortem: injuries fully explained by the fall and the water.
219 → 221	Del interviews Liam and Ruby as Margo's friends. Each, separately, frightened, hands over the letters and says: I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her.
222	Formal statements. Three deaths, five letters, two survivors. The detective division takes it with Del attached.
225	Margo's carrier records: Tessa's town, the road home, the car park at 22:40, no signal after 23:20. Data sessions only.
230 → 250	The cage letter examined against the four key letters and her unit paper: consistent with known samples, same paper stock.
235	Solicitor confirms lodging on Day -18. Her fear predates her death.
240	App provider: account exists, no content retained, no contact metadata. Tessa re-interviewed: gives the line about the cupboard; read as Margo doubting the reading, which fits Liam's account.
245	Coroner's officer asked to look again at Violet: no new physical evidence, finding stands. Brad's file: no change.
262	No further action. Both survivors informed.
263	Ruby talks to the Gazette.
265	Front page: the four friends of Violet Moore, the wake photograph. Liam, doorstepped: ask her who ran the meetings.

A5. Ally

Day	Ep	Event
266		Ally reads it. Del: we looked. Properly. There's nothing.

Day	Ep	Event
269	1	Ally has the paper, Ruby's willingness, and Del's nothing.
276	2	Ruby: the room, the letters read out, the boxes, Brad's habits: keys on the table moved twice, thank you like it cost him, up at five to run.
283	3	The café and the cinema owner: she was calling money in; and she was carrying a gold panel round asking whose hand it was. Ally does not know what that means. The download map shows a listener in a town 400 miles away from this week.
290	4	Liam talks. The fishmonger at Bay 3 rings the Tip Line: the young one was at her cage on the Wednesday. Ally gives it to Del and does not air it.
297	5	Ally asks: did Margo say anything to anyone.
300		Tessa writes, with the screenshot.
304	6	The words go on air, from a woman two hours up the coast: the thing in the cupboard is wrong. Ally: if the thing was wrong there was a real thing, and nobody has found one. What did Violet have in her last months that she hadn't before. Two signwriters write in about the panel.
311	7	I think against I know. The solicitor's slip dates the first. The letter that is kind to exactly one man.
318	8	The woman from the platform writes: the first train, the Monday the car was found, wet boots, cash. To Del, not on air. Ally asks: if you were on that train, write to me.
325	9	The panel described: black ground, twenty-six gold capitals and an ampersand, a crack across one corner, a small mark bottom right that was not her name and not his. One of a kind.
325 night		Brad takes it off the wall and burns it in the workshop stove.
326		The landlady, who has listened since Day 283, who half-saw the wake photograph online on Day 266 and dismissed it for the beard, who has heard six weeks of his habits from strangers, dusts his room on a Tuesday. Gone. She writes to Ally that night, privately, with her address.
327		Ally to Del, 07:00. Del to the other force.
328 → 332		He notices her.
332	10	Indistinguishable from episode nine.
333		Arrest on the identity offences. Prints against the Day 55 reference. Brad Collins, alive.

B. THE ACCESS LEDGER

One row per fact. Columns: fact · who holds it · from when · by what route · who they could lawfully tell · the recipient's earliest competent action on that fact alone. "Nobody" in the tell column means a duty of confidence or no lawful audience; "anyone" means it is not confidential.

B1. Facts that exist before Day 0

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
1	Violet holds cash, in a tin, more than painting explains	Violet, Margo, Brad (the tin, not the size), Liam from Day 2	Day ~1500	Violet's own act; Margo told for the tax question; Brad saw the tin at the unit	Anyone; Margo owes confidence	None: cash is lawful

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
2	The cash came from her mother's house	Violet, Margo	Day -1450	Violet told Margo; Margo's file note	Margo: nobody, without Violet's consent	None
3	Violet lent Brad the van money, no paper	Violet, Brad, Margo	Day -2000	Violet told Margo	Margo: nobody	None
4	Violet is calling in every debt, Brad's the largest	Violet, Margo, Brad	Day -120 / -110	Told directly	Margo: nobody	None
5	Liam owns a third of the yard	Liam, Violet, Brad	Day -2900; Brad from Day -500	Liam told Violet; Violet told Brad	Anyone: a lawful private shareholding; the yard's register is not public	None
6	Margo has a partner two hours up the coast and an app for her	Margo, Tessa; Violet (a Sunday and a green app, no name); Brad from Violet	Day -4000; Violet Day -600; Brad Day -500	Observation; Violet to Brad	Anyone	None
7	Brad's declared turnover is falling while the van stays busy	Brad; the pub landlord (his own payments); Margo (the pub's books)	Day -700	Margo does the pub's accounts	Margo: her client's affairs are confidential; a cash payment to a tradesman is lawful	None: nothing to report
8	Brad told the four a wedding; it was a marathon	Brad; Ruby	Day -250 / -200	A patient's son showed Ruby the results page	Anyone	None
9	Brad asked Liam what the yard would give for the van	Brad, Liam	Day -200	Direct	Anyone	None
10	Brad has a room, a name, and papers 400 miles away	Brad; the landlady knows a lodger under the other name	Day -400	His own act	The landlady: anyone; she has nothing to say	None
11	A panel in an unknown hand was hidden in Violet's roof space	Violet; four people she showed it to	Day -75; -70 to -40	The leak; she carried it round	Anyone	The four she showed: none, it is a panel
12	Violet is asking round town whose hand	Café owner, cinema owner, two signwriters; Brad from the café	Day -70 to -40	Direct	Anyone	Brad: accelerate
13	The ladder foot was undone, not sheared	Violet	Day -45	Her own inspection	Police, if she chose	Police: examine the ladder, no offence proven, no suspect named, note and advise
14	Violet fell from a ladder and was treated	Ruby (clinical record), Violet, the four	Day -45	Surgery	Ruby: nobody outside care	None

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
15	Four keys cut to one new padlock	Locksmith	Day -20	His book	Anyone asking	None
16	Four sealed envelopes lodged to be posted after her funeral	Solicitor	Day -18	Instruction	Nobody: client confidence, contents unknown to him	None; on death, post them
17	Violet believes one of the four is planning to kill her	Violet only	Day -45 to 0	Her inference from rows 11 and 13	Police	See Part C, Violet

B2. Facts created on Day 0 and by the death

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
18	Brad walked to and from Mariner's Row on Monday night	Brad; No. 14 saw a man's back	Day 0	Direct	No. 14: anyone	Police on Day 1 asked when she was last seen; the lane was not asked about. A listener lead at Day 290 onward
19	Brad's phone was at his flat all evening	Carrier (cell-site)	Day 0	Records, R8	Police on lawful request only	None without a suspect
20	Her debt book is gone	Brad; Margo notices its absence Day 8	Day 0 / 8	Margo helped the sister with paperwork	Margo: the sister	Sister: shrug; nobody else knew it existed
21	Violet died of a head injury at the foot of her stairs, unwitnessed	HCPD, Cortez, coroner, the four, the sister	Day 1 to 3	Scene, PM, R5	Public in outline	Coroner: accident (Ruling 1)
22	A fall six weeks earlier is on her GP record	Ruby, the PM (via GP)	Day -45 / 3	Record	Supports the finding	None
23	Liam found her and holds a key to the house	HCPD file	Day 1	Sudden-death report	Police	None; noted
24	The tin exists and went to the sister	The four, the sister, HCPD (noted as property)	Day 2 to 5	Liam's honesty	Anyone	None

B3. The letters and the cage

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
25	Each of the four holds a letter in her hand: I think, one of you, not the police, the cage	The four	Day 14	Post	Each: anyone. The letter asks them not to	Del, if handed it: read; no offence, no named suspect, a closed accident, a dead author; statement, note on file, ask the coroner's officer whether it changes anything: it does not (Ruling 1)

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
26	Which cage, and that it holds a thing	The four	Day 14	The letter	Anyone	None
27	Brad went to the cage on the Wednesday and the Friday	Brad; the Bay 3 fishmonger (Wed); the loading-bay camera (both, R7 thirty-one days)	Day 16, 18	Sight; tape	Fishmonger: anyone. Nobody asks until Day 290	Camera expires Day 47 and 49 unflagged: no case exists to flag it
28	What the genuine cage letter said: the ladder foot, the panel, the mark, "not Brad's hand, I taught him", and an instruction to pool everything odd each of you knows of the others	Brad only	Day 16	He read it	Nobody	It is ash
29	The panel is in Brad's possession	Brad	Day 16	Taken	Nobody	None
30	The cage letter (forged) says I know; the tin is Liam's; the yard; the ladder told to Liam; the oar; and never mentions a panel	The four, then Ruby's drawer	Day 19	The cage	Anyone; the letter itself says not the police	Del, if handed it on any day from 19: as row 25; plus, if a civilian alleges forgery, examination (Ruling 4): consistent
31	The brush is Violet's and was in her bucket at the unit until at least Day 2	The four; Liam saw it Day 2	Day 19	Recognition	Anyone	None: she put it there, they assume
32	Liam's third is confirmed in the room	The four	Day 27	Liam	Anyone	Del: a lawful shareholding
33	The letter has the money wrong	Margo only	Day 44	Her own file, row 2	Del, the room, Tessa	Del: a forgery allegation, then examination, then consistent: the allegation fails and the accuser is exposed to the room
34	Margo has stopped arguing with Brad	Brad	Day 47	Observation	Nobody	Go

B4. The vanish

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
35	Brad's van, phone, message and watch are at Kestrel Head	HCPD (Del), the three, the dog walker	Day 54	Scene	Public in outline	Del: MP, search, sample, interviews (Ruling 2)
36	His flat holds his passport, cards, tools, laptop; his accounts are thin and untouched after Day 53	HCPD	Day 54	Search	Police	Consistent with the water
37	A reference sample and prints exist for Brad Collins	HCPD	Day 55	MP practice	Police	Retained (Ruling 2)

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
38	He walked the ridge path and took the 05:47	The halt's platform camera (R7, expires Day 85); the clerk	Day 54	Sight; tape	Anyone, if asked	Nobody asks: the MP is presumed in the sea
39	A bag was placed at the ridge wall on Day 46	Brad	Day 46	His act	Nobody	None; the wall is empty by Day 54
40	The three were meeting weekly over letters from the dead woman	The three	Day 19 onward	Their own act	Del at interview Day 55	If told: Del reads the vanish as a grieving man. If shown the letters: Del reads the vanish as possible guilt, notes it on the closed file, cannot charge a presumed-dead man, cannot reopen a coroner's finding on a text message (Ruling 1). Either way, nothing moves
41	Brad's things are in boxes at Ruby's	Ruby, the landlord	Day 110	Clearance	Anyone	None; there is nothing in them
42	"The thing in the cupboard is wrong. It can't mean that."	Tessa (screenshot); Margo	Day 70	The app	Tessa: anyone; she does not know what cupboard	None until asked

B5. The stranger and the second death

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
43	A stranger on the green app knows things about Brad's death	Margo; Brad	Day 180	The app	Margo: Tessa, Del, Ruby, Liam. She tells nobody	If she told Del: a number that leads nowhere on a self-deleting app; nothing to pull; note. If she told Tessa: Tessa would tell her not to go
44	The meeting: Sunday, the point, eleven	Margo, Brad	Day 212	The app	As 43	As 43
45	Brad was absent from the lodgings Sunday to Monday	The landlady	Day 213	Told a job	Anyone	None until Day 327
46	Brad rode the trains south and north on cash	Guards, the halt clerk, platform camera (R7, expires Day 246), a woman on the platform	Day 214, 215	Sight	Anyone if asked	Nobody asks: the death is an apparent suicide (Rulings 5, 7)
47	Brad's prepaid pinged the Kestrel Head cell at 22:50 on Day 214	Carrier	Day 214	Records, R8	Police on a tower request	A tower dump is not ordered for an apparent suicide (Ruling 5)
48	Margo's car, ten minutes early, and her body three days later	HCPD, the dog walker, her office, Tessa	Day 215, 218	Scene	Public	Del: search; Ruling 6 link; Ruling 7 camera; PM
49	Margo had a partner nobody knew	Tessa, HCPD	Day 215	Tessa rang	Police	Statement; last movements

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
50	Margo's phone is not recovered	HCPD	Day 218	Search	Police	Carrier records (row 47's reach is the ruling)
51	Two survivors, five letters, three deaths	HCPD	Day 219 to 222	Del's own initiative and their fear	Police	The proper look: Days 222 to 262
52	The cage letter is consistent with her known samples	HCPD	Day 250	Examination	Police; the survivors are told	Nothing to act on
53	The letters were lodged on Day -18	Solicitor, HCPD	Day 235	Confirmation	Police	Her fear predates her death; it does not name an act

B6. What Ally can reach, and from whom

#	Fact	Ally's source	Day	Lawful	Route into the episode
54	Everything public	Gazette front page	266	Yes	Ep 1
55	The letters, the room, the boxes, Brad's habits	Ruby, on record	270 onward	Yes: Ruby owns her letter and holds the cage letter after its return from police	Ep 2
56	The debts being called in; the panel carried round	Café owner, cinema owner, two signwriters	280 to 304	Yes	Ep 3, 6, 9
57	Brad at the cage on the Wednesday	Bay 3 fishmonger, Tip Line	290	Yes, caller consents	To Del. Not aired
58	Liam's side	Liam	288	Yes	Ep 4
59	The screenshot	Tessa	300	Yes: Tessa owns it	Ep 6, anonymised, with consent
60	The 05:47 and the boots	The platform woman	318	Yes	To Del. Ally asks on air for others
61	A persistent listener in one town 400 miles away	Her own download map	283 onward	Yes, her own data	To Del on Day 326 as corroboration. Never aired
62	The solicitor's covering slip and postmark	Ruby's envelope	276	Yes	Ep 7
63	The lodger, the wall, the gap	The landlady, private message	326	Yes	To Del at 07:00. Never aired
64	Anything in the police file	Del		No, and she never gets it. Del says looked, nothing	Ally's sourcing never depends on the file

B7. Residue: what Brad's swap, vanish, contact and return leave behind

#	Residue	Where it sits	Who could find it	When it dies
R1	Two dawn visits to Cage 4	Loading-bay camera; Bay 3 fishmonger's memory	Anyone who asks the market; nobody does until Ally	Tape Day 47/49. Memory does not
R2	Her pen and paper used, drafts burned	Nothing survives; the pen is back in the unit and goes to the sister	Nobody	Day 17

#	Residue	Where it sits	Who could find it	When it dies
R3	A hand better than his public one	Only in the cage letter, which passes as hers	An examiner told to compare it against Brad's public work would find no match, because he never wrote in that hand as Brad	Never tested that way
R4	The bag at the ridge wall	Dry-stone wall, eight days	A walker between Day 46 and 53	Day 53
R5	The walk and the 05:47 on Day 54	Platform camera; the clerk	Anyone asking the halt	Tape Day 85; the clerk's memory fades
R6	The identity's paper trail: a dead infant's birth record and everything built on it	Public registers	Anyone who cross-checks births against infant deaths (Ruling 8)	Never
R7	Quarterly cash rent for over a year before he vanished	The landlady's rent book	Anyone who asks her, after Day 327	Never
R8	The prepaid's cell hits at Kestrel Head, Day 214	Carrier	A tower request (Ruling 5)	R8: seven years
R9	The trains, Days 213 to 215	Guards, clerk, platform camera; the woman on the platform	Anyone asking; the woman writes to Ally on Day 318	Tape Day 246
R10	Wet boots and a cash single at 05:40	The clerk, the woman	As R9	Memory
R11	Absence from the lodgings, Day 213 to 215, told as a job	The landlady	After Day 327	Never
R12	Ash in a workshop stove, Day 325	The stove	The other force, Day 333	Days
R13	A persistent download in one town from Day 283	Ally's analytics	Ally	Never
R14	The debt book	Burned with the drafts, Day 17	Nobody	Day 17
R15	A man's back in the lane at 22:30, Day 0	No. 14	Ally's listeners	Memory

C. THE SWEEP (STEP 1b, WITH THE RECIPIENT COLUMN)

Authored order ignored. For each person, from the first day they can know anything: what they can lawfully know · the earliest competent action · the recipient · the recipient's earliest response · every duty the combined facts trigger · the earliest consequential outcome. A suppression is named in the last column and must be world-supplied. The planned turns it is measured against: the swap (Day 18), the reading landing on Liam (Day 89), Brad's vanish (Day 53), Margo's death (Day 214), the survivors at the station (Day 219), Ally (Day 269), the identification (Day 333).

Rule applied throughout: an open route that reaches an authority and produces nothing is not a suppression. It is computed, the recipient is named, and the outcome is written down.

C1. Violet (Day –120 to Day 0)

Week	What she can know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties triggered	Outcome	Named cost
–11 to –7	Someone hid a panel in her roof; someone close has a hand she cannot place	Ask round town	Signwriters, café, cinema	Nobody knows the hand	None	Brad hears	She pays with the acceleration (Day –40)
–7	The ladder foot was undone	Report to police with the ladder	Del (Harbor Ward)	Examine the ladder; a bolt undone is not an offence proven; no suspect named; log, advise, offer nothing more	None: no offence, no named person	A record that she was frightened, and the person who did it learns she knows	Her refusal is competent and her stated reason is correct. Cost: her life
–3	The above, combined	Tell one of the four	Any of the four	Three would go to the police with her; one would move	None	25 per cent chance of telling the killer	Her design (four keys) is her answer to exactly this. Paid
–3	The above	Tell her solicitor why	Solicitor	Advise police; cannot compel	None on sealed envelopes	As row –7	She jokes instead. Consistent with the five

Verdict: PASS. Every route Violet had ends at the same desk with the same result and the killer informed. She chose the design the premise rests on. The sweep does not require her to be right; it requires her refusal to be hers, and it is.

C2. Brad (coherence with what he wants, not risk minimisation)

Week	Position	Action taken	Coherent because	Cheaper alternative rejected, and why
–16	The debt is called in; the exit is built	Decide she dies	Leaving as Brad Collins with a debt to a woman who forgets nobody lights up the cash economy Margo audits; dying as Brad Collins needs a grief; hers gives him both	Pay her: the cash is the exit. Move: a man who moved is a man who can be found
–7	The ladder	A fall that reads as a fall	Falls are his method; a survivor who slipped is survivable	A weapon leaves a wound the PM reads
–6	She is carrying the panel round	Wait for the debt conversation to give him a reason to be in her house	A visit about money is an ordinary visit	Retrieve the panel first: she has hidden it and he cannot search her without showing his hand
1	The stairs	One push, twenty minutes, the book, the lane	One impact, no second wound; the phone at home; on foot	Finish her if she breathed: a second injury is the end of accident
3	The key letter	Read the cage on the Wednesday, not the Saturday	The cage letter says what she reasoned and the panel is there; both must go before four people read them	Do nothing: the four pool what they know and he is the only one with weekends away, cash and a question about the van

Week	Position	Action taken	Coherent because	Cheaper alternative rejected, and why
3	The cage letter read	Swap, do not empty	Empty tells four people someone came early; a letter in her hand that says I know hands them weeks of work pointing elsewhere	Destroy the panel: it is the best thing he has made and she wrote that he could not have made it
3 to 7	The room	Defend Liam on she might have been wrong	An innocent surface, and the reading returns harder each time	Accuse Liam: legible forwards, and Liam reads him like an invoice
7	Margo has gone quiet	Go now, by the plan ready since Day 30	A second death in the group is a case; a grieving friend at Kestrel Head is not	Kill Margo now: see previous cell
8 to 25	Missing, presumed	Nothing. Listen.	The least-cost move is stillness	
26 to 30	Margo has not spoken in five months	Contact her from a prepaid, on Violet's information	She is the one person who can think alive; he needs to know whether she has been turned, and he wants to be the one who turns her (the want the least-cost test does not score)	Stillness: she may speak any week and he will not know until it is too late
31	She will not turn	The meeting at the point	A woman who blamed herself for one man at that cliff dies at that cliff and everyone has the reason ready; and she must hand him the phone	Leave her: the one person who thinks alive is now certain there is a stranger who knows too much
39 to 47	Ally is airing it	Stay. Listen.	Leaving costs the built life and would confirm to someone nearby that they had seen something	
47	The panel described	Burn it that night; watch the house	Someone near him may have seen it; he cannot know who; the object must not exist	Run: as above
47	The landlady changes	Notice her, as Margo	Too late: she wrote the night she looked	

Verdict: every action is coherent from inside and the two that look insane from outside (the contact, the return) are the compulsion the three real cases show, and the residue rows in B7 price them.

C3. Liam

Week	What he can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
1	He found her; the tin	Hand the tin to the sister	Sister	Takes it	None	Done Day 5	None
3	The key letter	Take it to Del	Del	Row 25: read, note, no offence, ask the coroner's officer, nothing changes	None	Nothing; the other three learn he went	Violet's reasons still live; he holds nothing but a maybe

Week	What he can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
4	The cage letter names his third and says the tin is his	As above, with a letter in her hand that names his secret and calls the money his	Del	Statement; the yard's affairs are lawful; the letter is not an allegation of an act by him; note	None	Liam is the man who brought police a letter accusing himself; the third is on a police file; nothing else	Self-interest lock, tested: holds, because the only document he owns points at him
6	Brad defends him, loses	As above					Holds
8	Brad is missing	Tell Del at interview: we were working her letters and they had begun to point at me	Del	Row 40: reads the vanish as guilt or grief; either way no charge, no reopening; Liam is now the man the letters pointed at, on the file, beside a friend who killed himself	None	Nothing moves; the file now contains him	Holds, and harder: a dead friend's message plus a letter pointing at him is worse for him than silence
13	It lands on him	I am frightened of Ruby	Del	What has she done? Nothing. Note	None	Nothing	Holds: fear of the letter still exceeds fear of Ruby
14 to 30	Silence, estrangement	As above					Holds; nothing has changed
31	Margo is dead at the same cliff	Go in, now	Del (who is already coming to him)	The proper look	Police duty on three deaths	Days 222 to 262	The break point, exactly where finding 2 put it: fear of a person exceeds fear of the letter

Verdict: PASS. The lock is renewed at every change of facts and breaks on the change the premise breaks it on. Note for the attack: at Week 8 Liam's route is open and computed, and it makes his position worse, which is why he does not take it.

C4. Ruby (with the professional duty run separately)

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
-7	Violet fell from a ladder	Treat, record	Record		Clinical: done		

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
1	Violet is dead; the record shows a prior fall	Nothing to act on			Reading the record without a clinical reason is a breach; she does it	Nothing	Cost: a breach she never mentions
3	The key letter	Take it to Del	Del	Row 25	Professional duty tested: a written fear by a dead person names no living person at risk; safeguarding duties attach to the living; no duty arises	Nothing; Violet's instruction broken for nothing	Lock: her reading is she was frightened, then she fell, and she read every face in that kitchen and saw no lie
4	Liam's third is true, so the letter is right about something	Duty renews on the new fact. Go to Del with both letters	Del	Statement; a lawful secret; the letter alleges no act; note; ask the coroner's officer: no new physical evidence (Ruling 1)	None: still no living person at risk	Nothing, and Liam learns she went	Open route, computed, does not deliver. She does not take it because it costs her the room and gains nothing, which is a reason the world supplies
6	The tin claim; Liam denies	As above					Holds
8	Brad missing with a message	Tell Del about the letters	Del	Row 40	None: Brad is presumed dead, nobody alive is named at risk	Nothing moves	She reads the message as grief because she loves him; and Violet's reasons still live because the letter's suspects are still alive
13	It lands on Liam	I am frightened of him	Del	What has he done? Nothing. Note	None	Nothing	Holds
16	The boxes	Nothing in them					
31	Margo dead	Go in	Del (already coming)	The proper look	Police duty	Days 222 to 262	Break point: fear of a person
38	No further action	Talk to the Gazette	Gazette	Front page		Ally	Her fear made public

Verdict: PASS, with the thin lock named: from Day 27 Ruby has an open route to Del, every week, that produces a note on a closed file and a friend who knows she broke the dead woman's instruction. The spine does not silence her; it computes what she would get and it is nothing.

C5. Margo

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
-17	Violet is calling in debts; Brad owes most	Nothing: lawful			Accountant's confidence to Violet		
2	The debt book is gone	Tell the sister	Sister	Shrug	None	Nothing	
3	The key letter	Take it to Del	Del	Row 25	Professional duty tested: she is an accountant, not a regulated reporter of suspected homicide; nothing in the letter is a financial crime	Nothing	Holds as Ruby's
4	Liam's third (new to her)	As above					Holds
6 to 7	The letter has the money wrong	(a) Say so in the room. (b) Take it to Del as a forgery	(a) The room. (b) Del	(a) The room asks how she knows; she must say Violet told her a thing she promised not to repeat, in front of the person who forged it. (b) Forgery allegation on a closed accident: examination (Ruling 4): consistent with known samples: the allegation fails; she is the friend who called the dead woman's letter a fake	None	(a) Brad knows tonight. (b) Brad knows in a week and the letter has a police stamp saying it is hers	The thinnest lock in the spine, six days, named: she wants certainty before accusing a friend, she runs the sums three nights, and the sums point at the man she has never liked, which is the reason she distrusts them. Paid: Day 53
8	Brad is gone	Tell Del: I think he forged it	Del	Forgery allegation against a presumed-dead man on a closed case: examination: consistent: nothing	None	Nothing, and she has said in public what she cannot live with	Guilt lock: she chooses she was wrong about him. Available to her because her certainty rests on what Violet told her, and Violet lied about cigarettes with total confidence

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
10	Guilt	Tell Tessa	Tessa	Tessa: what cupboard? Margo does not explain	None	A screenshot	Eleven years of compartments
13	It lands on Liam	Say the letter is wrong	The room	As Week 6 (a), with a dead man as the only alternative	None		Holds: the alternative is that she killed Brad
26 to 30	A stranger who knows	Tell Del; tell Tessa	Del: nothing to pull. Tessa: do not go	None		Holds: the stranger is the only person offering her the reading she can live in	
31	The meeting	Do not go					She goes ten minutes early

Verdict: PASS. The six-day lock is the one the step-3 attack should hit first.

C6. Tessa

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties	Outcome
10	A line about a cupboard	Ask	Margo	Does not explain	None	Screenshot kept
31	Margo has not answered since Sunday	Ring the office; ring the police	Havenbay police	Statement; last movements; she is on the file by 15:30 on Day 215	None	The partner nobody knew is found by the review on the first day
35	Re-interviewed	Give the line	Detective	Read as doubt about the reading; on file	None	Nothing
43	Ally asks	Write, with the screenshot	Ally	On air, anonymised		Ep 6

Verdict: PASS. Tessa acts on the first day every time. What she holds does not carry a who.

C7. Del and HCPD

Day	The file on the desk	Earliest competent action	Duties triggered	Outcome	Why it stops there
1	Unwitnessed sudden death, head injury, stairs, secure house	Scene, PM, coroner, door-knock	Sudden death procedure	Accident (Ruling 1)	Nothing at the scene says otherwise; the PM cannot
54	MP at a known site, message, watch, seven weeks after his friend's death	Search, sample, flat, interviews	MP procedure (Ruling 2)	Missing, presumed	Nobody mentions letters; if they had, row 40

Day	The file on the desk	Earliest competent action	Duties triggered	Outcome	Why it stops there
215	A second car from the same four at the same site	Link the files (Ruling 6); search; Tessa's statement	MP, then sudden death	Suicide pending PM	
218	Body, PM, phone absent	Last movements (Ruling 5); camera (Ruling 7); interview the surviving friends	Sudden-death procedure; a cluster	Del reaches Liam and Ruby on Day 219 before they reach her	Competent and on time
222	Five letters, three deaths, two accusations	Examination (Ruling 4); solicitor; coroner's officer; app provider; carrier	All run, Days 222 to 262	Consistent; lodged Day -18; no new physical evidence; no content; no recoverable contact	Nothing where they are looking, because nothing is there
327	A landlady's message via Ally	Other force, prints, arrest		Day 333	

Verdict: PASS. Nothing is withheld from Del and she initiates the survivor interviews herself. What the file cannot do is name a living man or reopen a finding without evidence of an act.

C8. Everyone else

Person	Knows	Earliest action	Recipient	Response	Why nothing follows
Solicitor	Four sealed envelopes, Day -18	Post after funeral	The four		Contents unknown to him; no duty
Sister	Tin, house, unit, an empty cage at Day 82	None			An empty cage is an empty cage
Locksmith	Four keys, Day -20	None			Nobody asks until Ally
No. 14	A man's back, Day 0	None	Police, if asked	Not asked	The question on Day 1 was when she was last seen
Bay 3 fishmonger	Brad at the cage, Day 16	None until asked	Tip Line, Day 290	To Del	A friend at a dead friend's cage is not a thing to report
Pub landlord	Paid Brad cash for a year	None			Lawful
Café, cinema, two signwriters	A gold panel, whose hand	None	Ally, Day 283 onward		A panel
Landlord (flat)	Rent stopped	Clear, boxes to Ruby			
The halt clerk, the platform woman	Wet boots, cash, Day 215	None until asked	Ally, Day 318	To Del	A man with wet boots on a morning train
The landlady	A lodger under the other name; his absences; the panel on his wall; his habits	Write to Ally the night the panel is gone (Day 326). The other route, her local police, would put a constable on her doorstep the day he came home	Ally, then Del, then the other force	Day 333	Her window is hours and she uses them
Ally	Everything in B6	Del first, every time	Del		Airing a name would tell him which town; she never has one to air

C9. Causal order check (pipeline rule 5)

Claimed cause	Date	Claimed effect	Date	Holds
The debt called in	−110	Decision	−110	Yes
The panel shown round	−70 to −40	Brad hears; acceleration	−40; 0	Yes
The ladder	−45	Violet's belief, the cage, the letters	−20 to −18	Yes
The key letter names the cage	14	Brad's first visit	16	Yes
First visit	16	The writing	17	Yes
Margo's file	44	Margo's silence	47	Yes
Margo's silence noticed	47	The vanish	53	Yes; the bag was placed on Day 46 under a plan ready since Day 30, so the trigger and the readiness are separately dated
Brad's vanish	53	Margo's guilt; the reading lands	54; 89	Yes
Contact	180	Meeting	214	Yes
Margo's death	214	Survivors go in	219	Yes
Front page	265	Ally	266	Yes
Panel aired	325	Panel burned; landlady looks	325 night; 326	Yes

Sweep verdict: PASS. No first-action date precedes its planned turn with a consequential outcome. Two thin locks: Margo Days 47 to 53; Ruby from Day 27. Both are open, computed and world-supplied. Both go to the attack first.

D. THE OBJECTS

D1. X, what Violet hid: the panel

A gilded alphabet panel. Oak, about 30 by 40 centimetres, black ground, twenty-six capitals and an ampersand in water gilding, a crack across one corner from the day the ceiling board came down, and a small maker's mark bottom right that is not a name: a monogram of the initials he lives under now. Made by Brad at Violet's bench on Tuesday nights over ten months, in a hand and at a standard he had never shown anyone in Havenbay, kept in the roof space over her racks because his flat and his van had to survive a search.

Why it says "prepared exit" only when combined. Alone it is a beautiful panel with a mark nobody knows. Beside the four's separate pieces it is one of the four making a name for himself somewhere else: Ruby's marathon told as a wedding (he lies about where he goes), Margo's pub books (he has been taking his income off paper for two years), Liam's question in the crane cab (he priced the van), and Violet's own expert judgement, which was wrong in the one way that matters: it is not Brad's hand, I taught him, he cannot do this. The genuine cage letter asked the four to pool everything odd they knew of one another. Pooled, the

pieces name one man. That is why the letter had to go, and it is why the panel had to go with it: the mark on it is the mark he signs with now.

#	Constraint (v8)	Panel	Brush (Fable's seed)
1	Unique physical object, cannot be posted or copied	Yes: hand-gilded, one crack, one mark	Yes
2	Meaningless alone, damning beside what the four separately knew	Yes, as above	Fails: it is hers; nothing the four know makes it mean anything
3	Not the motive	Yes: the debt is the motive; the panel accelerates	Yes
4	Something Violet could plausibly have found	Yes: a leak, a ceiling board, a wrapped thing above her own racks	Fails: she made it; nothing was found
5	Something he wants	Yes: the best thing he has ever made, in the self he could not show, and she wrote that he could not have made it	Fails: he has no use for her brush
6	Innocuous in a stranger's house four hundred miles away	Yes: an alphabet thing on a lodger's wall; the mark is his own initials there	Yes, barely: an odd brush
7	Describable by Ally without holding it	Yes: she carried it round for a month asking whose hand; four people can describe it	Yes: from across the road

Verdict: the panel passes seven of seven. The brush passes four and fails 2, 4 and 5 as X, and is the decoy.

D2. The decoy: the brush

Violet's own brush, sable on a handle cut from a broken oar, green electrical tape at the ferrule. In her bucket at the unit until Day 17, when Brad took it with his unit key. Everyone in the room recognises it because it is hers. Only its meaning is his.

The false meaning, and the two truths it rides on. The forged letter says: the oar came from the yard the week Liam bought in; he gave it to her that day and told her how he had paid for it; she cut a handle from it so she would see it every day and remember she had said nothing; the money in her tin is his, every quarter since, for her silence. Two claims in that letter are verifiable and true, and both are things Violet told only Brad: Liam owns a third of the yard (row 5), and there is a tin (row 1, and the whole room saw it go to the sister on Day 5). Liam confirms the first on Day 27. From that day the letter has earned the right to be believed about the third claim, which is the lie.

Where it fails. Only on the money. Margo alone knows the tin came from Violet's mother's house (row 2). She has it in her own hand in her own file, Day -1450. Violet did not get her own money wrong. So the letter is not Violet's.

Why it cannot fail earlier or elsewhere. Liam can deny paying her and cannot prove a negative. The sister does not know where the cash came from. Ruby never knew of the tin. Brad wrote nothing else that any of them could test.

D3. The two cupboard letters, as claims

Claim	Genuine (Day -19), read only by Brad	Forged (Day 17), read by the four
Certainty	I think, and I may be wrong	I know, now

Claim	Genuine (Day –19), read only by Brad	Forged (Day 17), read by the four
Grounds	The ladder bolt undone; a panel in a hand she cannot place, hidden in her roof; a mark	The ladder: she had told Liam which ladder. The yard. The tin. The oar
Who	Nobody named. One line: it is not Brad's hand, I taught him, he cannot do this	Nobody named. Every line leans one way
The thing beside it	The panel: whose hand, whose mark	The brush: Liam's oar
Instruction	Each of you write down everything odd you know of the other three from the last year, and read them together	Read this together, and be careful
Mentions Brad	Once, to clear him	Once, as the one she sent up the ladder, kindly
Retrospective tells		I know against I think; the letter kind to exactly one man; no panel, though four people in town saw her carrying one

D4. The motive, stated once

The money. Violet lent him the van and his start, cash, no paper, Day –2000, and on Day –110 told him she wanted it back for the lawyer. The exit was already built and the cash was already in it. From inside his head: a debt follows a man who moves; nobody chases a debt to a man who died; a man who dies off Kestrel Head needs a grief the whole city will accept; and Violet's death is the one grief that makes his own read true, seven weeks later, to everyone including the police. The panel is not why. It is why it was that month.

E. THE RULINGS

Eight questions. Seven are v8's queue plus the camera question added at the closure check; the eighth is the spine's own, because Brad's papers cannot exist without it. For each: the question, what the spine needs, what happens otherwise. Nothing here is ruled.

1. What supports an accidental-fall finding on an unwitnessed death with head trauma, and what reopens it? The spine needs: a secure house, a single impact consistent with the stair, modest alcohol, and a GP-recorded fall six weeks earlier are enough for a coroner to record accident after a competent post-mortem; and reopening requires new evidence of an act by a person, not a document expressing fear, not a friend's suicide, not a second death elsewhere. If it goes the other way (a written allegation reopens it): the finding reopens on Day 222, the police are then running an open homicide with a document examination inside it, and Ally arrives into an active case rather than a closed one. The premise's "they find nothing" survives; "Ally comes to it afterwards" does not.

2. Missing-person status, search duration, and reference-sample practice when there is no body. The spine needs: a vehicle, a message and a smashed watch at a known site make him high-risk missing presumed in the water; the search stands down within days; a DNA reference and lifted prints are taken from the home on the first or second day and retained indefinitely against a future body; the file stays missing, not dead, with no petition. If it goes the other way (no sample is taken for a presumed suicide): Day 333 has nothing to match him against and identification needs family DNA or his own confession. Fixable but slower and it loses the line the premise is built to deliver.

3. Who can petition to have a missing man declared dead, and how fast? The spine needs: only family or a person with a financial interest, after a waiting period measured in years, and nobody in this story has either the standing or the wish. If it goes the other way (a friend can, and quickly): Ruby might, out of kindness, to close his affairs; a declaration puts his death on paper and adds nothing to Brad's safety or danger. Cosmetic.

4. Is authentication of a material posthumous document routine, discretionary, or only on express dispute? The spine needs: any of the three. The letter is examined on Day 230 to 250 and passes as consistent with known samples on the same paper stock, because he was taught by her and wrote at her bench with her pen. The spine still needs to know which, because it decides whether the examination happens at Day 222 without anyone saying forgery (routine), or only because a detective chose to (discretionary), or not at all unless Margo's line is read as a dispute (on-dispute). If on-dispute: the examination may never happen, the file carries an unexamined letter, and Ally's later claim of forgery is untested rather than tested and wrong. Weaker, not fatal.

5. What does a last-movements review reach on an apparent suicide when the device is lost: carrier records, app metadata, the prepaid connection? The spine needs: her own carrier records (cell-site, data sessions), reached on request; the app provider confirming an account and retaining no content and no contact list; and no tower request, because a tower dump is an investigative tool for an offence and there is no offence. If it goes the other way (a tower request is routine for a death at that site): an unregistered prepaid pings the same cell at 22:50 on Day 214, the review has a second phone at the point, and the death is no longer an uncomplicated suicide on Day 225. That is the finding the closure check left PARTLY, and it is this ruling.

6. Does a death at a known disappearance site automatically link the cases? The spine needs: yes, and Del links them on Day 215 by hand anyway; linking means the files are read together, it does not mean either death is reclassified. If it goes the other way (no link): Del reaches the survivors four days later, when they come in themselves. Cosmetic.

7. Camera coverage at the cliff and its approaches, and does a review pull it for an apparent suicide? The spine needs: one camera at the car park entrance covering vehicles, pulled for Margo, showing her car arrive at 22:50 and nobody on foot, because the coast path from the landward side does not pass it; no camera on the point. If it goes the other way (a camera on the path or the point): it shows two figures at 23:00 on Day 214, and the spine fails at Day 218. If the review does not pull it at all: the tape expires Day 246 unwatched and the same nothing results, more cheaply. The spine wants it pulled, because a competent review that finds her alone is stronger than one that never looked.

8. Identity documents: can a man build a usable second identity from the birth record of a child who died in infancy, without an accomplice, in Havenbay's world? The spine needs: yes, slowly, because the registers of births and infant deaths are not cross-checked at issue, and the identity is only exposed when someone with a name and a town asks. If it goes the other way (cross-checked at issue): the exit needs a bought identity, which needs a seller, which is an accomplice, which v8 settled against. This is the ruling the spine added.

Also decided here without a ruling, and flagged as geography rather than process: Kestrel Head as the cliff, at the end of Kestrel Road beyond the lighthouse. It is a naming, and it costs an exterior the art system does not yet have.

F. PRE-FLIGHT: THE THIRTEEN OBJECTIONS

#	Objection	Answer	Result
1	Why was the decisive material not found at the time?	Because it did not exist where anyone looked: the panel left in a rucksack on Day 53, the genuine letter was ash on Day 17, and the one fact that breaks the forgery was a promise Violet made Margo keep. Nobody was lazy: the scene, the PM, the search, the sample, the examination and the review all ran.	Pass
2	Does the antagonist act in his own interest at every point?	Part C2: every action is coherent with what he wants, including the two compulsions, which are priced in B7.	Pass
3	Would a real person do the small thing this needs?	Violet carries a panel round asking whose hand: she ranked handwriting out loud. Margo sits in the car until the hour. Ruby keeps the boxes. Tessa screenshots one strange line. Liam hands the tin over. Each is from the five.	Pass
4	Is the motive one an ordinary reader accepts?	He owed her money he had already spent on leaving, and she had started asking for it.	Pass
5	Is any discovery a coincidence wearing a coat?	The leak is the one accident in the spine and it is upstream of everything; the fishmonger, the platform woman and the landlady are found by asking, on air, in a serialised programme whose whole engine is that strangers answer. The landlady is a lodger's landlady, not a stranger who happened past.	Pass, with the leak flagged for the attack
6	Does a reader with no context understand every word?	Cage, panel, brush, tin, ladder, cliff, train. "Gilding" needs one line. No procedure near the hook.	Pass
7	Can a reader hold the cast on one pass?	Violet, then four names, then Del and Ally. Tessa and the landlady arrive one at a time and late. The solicitor, sister, fishmonger, clerk and café owner are functions with no names.	Pass
8	Is it clear what the crime is, immediately?	A woman died on her stairs and her four friends were sent keys. Two of them are alive and afraid of each other.	Pass
9	Can Ally source everything she says she knows?	Part B6, rows 54 to 64. Nothing comes from the file.	Pass
10	Does anything break its own rules?	Tips to Del never on air (rows 57, 60, 61, 63). The Tip Line keeps no metadata. All-party consent: Ally records nobody covertly. The letter is a letter, not a recording.	Pass
11	If the premise claims a route is the ONLY one, find the second route in the ledger.	The premise claims no wall. Every route to Del is open from Day 14 and each is computed in Part C to produce a note on a closed file. The second route to Brad is the download map (row 61), which gives a town and not a house, and it is used.	Pass
12	Is the stake a body, freedom, family, identity or present danger?	Three bodies, a man's freedom, and a woman four hundred miles away who has told nobody but Ally.	Pass
13	Does anything decisive rest on a small number?	No. Ten minutes early is character, not evidence. Nothing turns on a time or a sum.	Pass
+	Is the antagonist a person or a mechanism?	A man who was the pet of the room for seven years and was cleverer than all of them, who built a self nobody was allowed to see, and who kept the one thing that proved it because she said he could not have made it.	Person

Score: 13 of 13, with objection 5's leak flagged for the step-3 attack.

G. WHAT FABLE MAY BE TOLD

The redacted brief for step 4. Paste this block and nothing else. It contains what Ally has on the day she starts and what the city knows. It does not contain which of the four, what was behind the door beyond what the survivors say, where anyone is, or anything from Parts A to F.

Brief for the opening of Episode One, working title The Friend They Mourned.

You wrote the five as people. They are canon. Here is what happened to them, as Havenbay knows it, and what Ally holds on the morning she decides to make the episode.

The public account. Violet Moore, 44, signwriter, died at the foot of her own stairs on a Monday night about nine months ago. Head injury. Police attended, there was a post-mortem, a coroner recorded an accident. She had four close friends: Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera, Brad Collins. Two weeks after she died, each of them got a key in the post with a letter in her hand. The letter said she thought one of the four was planning to kill her, that she did not know which and might be wrong, that they were not to go to the police and why, and that what she had found was behind a door only the four of them could open. They went together on the Saturday. Behind the door was a second letter in her hand, longer, that said she knew, and a thing of hers beside it. The survivors will not say what the thing was, only that it was hers.

They worked the letter for weeks at Ruby's kitchen table. Seven weeks after the funeral Brad drove to Kestrel Head at night, left his phone on the seat with one message on it, and was never found. His watch was on the rocks. Police searched and stood down. Five months after that Margo Rivera's car was found in the same car park, ten minutes before eleven on the dashboard clock, and her body came into the harbour three days later. Police reviewed it and called it what it looked like: a woman who had blamed herself for the friend who went off the same cliff. She had a partner two hours up the coast that none of them knew about.

Liam and Ruby each went to the police within the week. Not to accuse. To say: I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her. The police looked, properly, for six weeks: the letters were examined and are hers, the solicitor confirmed she lodged them three weeks before she died, the coroner's finding stands, nothing was found. No further action. Ruby talked to the Gazette. The front page has the four of them at the wake.

What Ally holds on day one. The paper. A sergeant she trusts saying: we looked, properly, there's nothing. Ruby willing to talk. Liam not, yet. A Tip Line that has had nothing on this. No relationship to either survivor; she has never met them.

What the opening must do. Get the death and the keys inside the first forty-five seconds. Land on two living people taking each other apart in public over a dead woman's letter, and a podcaster who was not there for any of it. Under 330 words. Ally asks on microphone before she records anyone. Nothing in her voice claims to know what the police could not find.

Do not invent: which of the four; what the thing behind the door was; what the second letter said beyond that it said she knew and pointed, over weeks, at Liam; anything about where anyone is now; any procedure. If the opening needs a fact not in this brief, leave a gap and mark it.

No em dashes.

End of brief. Everything above this line stays in this file.